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Battle-Ready CM

- Omar Abdullah led JKNC to victory in two of the three Lok Sabha seats, but himself lost to Abdul Rashid aka 'Engineer' Sheikh from Baramulla
- In October, he scripted a comeback by taking the JKNC to victory in the assembly polls in the Jammu & Kashmir Union Territory
- In all, NC won 42 of the 56 seats it contested; Omar won both his seats– Ganderbal and Budgam
- The new chief minister now faces the challenge of delivering on his main 'guarantees': generating employment, tackling inflation, delivery of free gas and electricity

soup of King's parties, an army primed to inflict a thousand cuts. An unprecedented 63 per cent turnout—a far cry from the old days of boycotts—was evidence that people thirsted for change. No one could risk predicting which way they would go. But once all the calculations about fast-mutating political leanings were done, their choice was unequivocal. The NC won 42 of the 56 seats it contested; a mere three short of the 46 required in the new 90-seat assembly. While ally Congress had a poor six, it was good enough. The sweep of its endorsement was impressive—Omar's party took 35 of the 39 it contested in the Valley, and even seven of its 17 Jammu contests. Icing on the cake: the 54-year-old Abdullah scion won both Ganderbal and Budgam, and was sworn in as the first CM of the Union Territory of Jammu and Kashmir on October 16. By any account, a stunning turnaround.

But what Omar has won is only the right to fight a new battle, a more daunting one. Central laws passed in the interim have vested much of the levers of power in the hands of the lieutenant governor—land and citizenship, police, law and order, powers to appoint/transfer top bureaucrats and judicial officers, the Anti-Corruption Bureau, prosecution, prisons. Hence, restoration of statehood becomes a natural demand; the resolution passed soon after Omar took over is both an expression of the sentiment on the street and a means to deflect disenchantment over the expectations he may not be able to meet. He realises that to address immediate issues—high unemployment, inflation, the promised delivery of free gas and electricity—there has to be a modicum of cordiality with the Centre and its representative, LG Manoj Sinha. So he has been treading a cautious path.

Not an easy balance to attain: oppositionality with cordiality. It didn't take long for political rivals to question his reconciliatory approach towards New Delhi. Peoples Conference chairman Sajad Lone, for instance, chose one of the moments of temperance to let go this taunt: "The belligerence has been replaced by humiliating visuals of you gifting shawls to the top BJP leadership." To restore its dignity, Omar's administration has sought to wrest some initiative back—a reversion to traditional academic session of October-November in the Valley from the March-April one started by the UT administration; a sub-committee to examine the demand for a tapering down of the 60 per cent reservation; an administrative reshuffle in December. But the holy grail, for now, is statehood. ■